when I was eleven/twelve, those, those were the days where I used to hop back on his scooter and play a couple of practice matches a day. You know, first half of the innings I would be batting on Shivaji Park, the second half some other match at Azad Maidan. Sir would be taking me all over Mumbai to make sure that I got match practice.

On a lighter note, in the last twenty-nine years Sir has never ever said ‘well played’ to me because he thought I would get complacent and I would stop working hard. Maybe he can, he can push his luck and wish me now ‘well done’ on my career, and because there are no more matches, sir, in my life. I will be witnessing cricket, and cricket will always stay in my heart, but you had an immense contribution in my life, so thank you very much.

My cricket for Mumbai started right here on this ground, the Mumbai Cricket Association, which is so dear to me. I remember landing from New Zealand at four o’clock in the morning and turning up for a game at eight o’clock here, just because I wanted to be part of Mumbai cricket, not that anyone forced me or Mumbai Cricket Association pressurized me to be here, but that was for the love of Mumbai cricket. And thank you very much – the president is here – thank you very much, along with your team, for taking care of me and looking after my cricket.

The dream was obviously to, to play for India, and that’s where my association with BCCI started. BCCI was fantastic, right from the, from my debut. Believing in my ability, selecting me in the squad at the age of sixteen was, was a big step. So thanks to all the selectors for having, having faith in me and the BCCI for giving me the freedom to express myself out in the middle. Things would have been different if you had not been behind me, and I really appreciate your support. Especially when I was injured, you were right with me and making sure that all the treatments were taken care of and I got fit and fine, playing back for India.

The journey has been special, the last twenty-four years. I have played with many, many senior cricketers, and even before that there were many senior cricketers whom I watched on television – they inspired me to play cricket and play it the right way. Thanks so much to all those senior cricketers. Unfortunately I have not been able to play with them, but I have high regards for all their achievements and all their contributions.

We see it on the mega-screen, Rahul, Laxman, Sourav – Anil is not here – and my team-mates right here in front of me. You are, you are like